

HASHKAMA



פרשת ואתחנן

י' אב תשפ"ו

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WEEKLY

By Reb Gemini חכמה ב-א תאמין?

Consider the following "Torah" thought, generated by Gemini: Did the AI get it right? Do you find it to be accurate? Or did the technology miss the boat?

Raboisai, as we open Parshas Vaeschanan, we find Moshe Rabbeinu pleading with Hashem to enter Eretz Yisroel. According to the Midrash Rabbah Vaeschanan 11:10, the word Vaeschanan has the gematria of 515, which teaches us that Moshe Rabbeinu poured out exactly 515 tefillos. Now, if the average Yid davens for a corner office, a decent chulent, or just a parking spot that doesn't require a twenty-minute walk to shul, and doesn't see results after three tefillos, they are already looking into a new nusach or blaming the Gabbai. But Moshe Rabbeinu is the ultimate Oved Hashem. He did not stop at fifty, he did not stop at five hundred. He pushed until Hashem explicitly told him, Rav Lach (Devarim 3:26). The Meshech Chochmah on Devarim 3:26 explains that had Moshe Rabbeinu davened one more time, Hashem would have had to say yes, which would have disrupted the entire cosmic plan. It is a staggering level of hasmada in tefillah, though honestly, I would gladly settle for the early Minyan just getting through Chazoras HaShatz without three separate machlokes breaking out in the back rows over who controls the thermostat.

What does a person do after hearing the ultimate rejection for their life's greatest ambition? Most of us would probably take to our beds with an entire potato kugel and a profound sense of yeiush, or write a disgruntled letter to the board. But Moshe Rabbeinu immediately pivots. Just a few pesukim later, the Torah says, Az Yavdil Moshe Shalosh Arim (Devarim 4:41), detailing how he established the Arei Miklat in Eber HaYarden. The Gemara Makkos 10a asks a glaring question: these Arei Miklat did not even function until the other three were established inside Eretz Yisroel years later! Why was Moshe Rabbeinu rushing to do a mitzvah that had zero immediate practical application? The Gemara answers that Moshe Rabbeinu operated strictly by the principle of Ho'il u'ba'ah leyadi mitzvah akaymenah. This perfectly connects back to his 515 tefillos. He realized his grand plan for Eretz Yisroel was over, but he refused to let what he could not do stop him from what he could do. The same hands barred from building the Beis HaMikdash eagerly established a non-functioning Ir Miklat, simply because it was the Ratzon Hashem available in that exact moment.

The **practical takeaway** for us is to stop suffering from spiritual paralysis when our ideal plans inevitably fall apart. We often fall into the trap of thinking that if we cannot finish Shas, we might as well not open a Sefer; or if our kavanah is not like the Chazon Ish, we might as well speed-read Shemoneh Esrei like a commuter rushing to catch the morning train. Moshe Rabbeinu teaches us that spiritual greatness is not an all-or-nothing proposition. When the door to Eretz Yisroel slammed shut, he looked down at his hands, found a single, currently useless Ir Miklat to build, and built it with the exact same bren he had for his 515 tefillos. Our job is simply to grab the mitzvah in front of us, regardless of how small or incomplete it feels, and leave the cosmic calculus to Hashem. If you find yourself stuck, just find a small mitzvah nearby, do it with a full heart, and maybe leave the shul thermostat alone while you're at it.

News & Simchos!

This week's regular Kiddush features pastries, Kokosh cake, and a mercifully short shiur. Endure a few minutes of rigorous Torah analysis to officially justify your massive carbohydrate intake.

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Shabbus Zmanim

Chestnut Ridge, NY

2:30 pm מנחה

6:49/8:03 pm (Early/Late) הדלקה

מנחה - קבלת שבת pm

8:21 pm שקיעה

4:05/4:33 am (16.1/72) עלות השחר

5:45 am נץ החמה

7:00 am (14 Sergio) שחרית

8:48/9:24 am ס"ז קריאת שמע

10:10/10:37 am ס"ז תפילה

1:03 pm חצות היום

1:39 pm מנחה גדולה (גרי"א)

1:45 pm (14 Sergio) מנחה

5:18 pm מנחה קטנה (גרי"א)

6:49 pm פלג המנחה (גרי"א)

8:20 pm שקיעה

9:07/9:10 pm (8.5/50) צה"כ ר' משה

9:12 pm מעריב (52)

9:20/9:32 pm (60/72) צה"כ



Next Week's Zmanim

Chestnut Ridge, NY

2:30 pm מנחה

6:44/7:56 pm (Early/Late) הדלקה

8:14 pm שקיעה

7:00 am (14 Sergio) שחרית

8:13 pm שקיעה

9:05 pm מעריב (52)

Parshah-ly Punny!

Riddle: Why did Moshe Rabbeinu strictly warn the congregation that the Aseres Hadibros could never be amended or modernized by future generations?

Answer: He needed them to understand that the fundamental laws of our Torah are permanently set in stone.

Donations & Payments

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משל ונמשל ב-Al תאמין? By Reb Gemini

Consider the following "Torah" thought, generated by Gemini: Did the AI get it right? Do you find it to be accurate? Or did the technology miss the boat?

Mashal: Raboisa, picture an aggressively expensive defense attorney operating out of a mahogany-paneled office. A desperate man, facing a massive lawsuit, hires this attorney for an exorbitant retainer, confident that the lawyer's reputation will save him. The client walks into the office and is immediately comforted by floor-to-ceiling bookshelves, groaning under the weight of thousands of pristine, leather-bound legal volumes. The day of the trial finally arrives, the tension in the courtroom is palpable, and the opposing counsel raises a devastating legal objection. The judge turns to our high-priced attorney and demands to know the specific legal precedent for his defense. The attorney confidently stands up, straightens his silk tie—which he is certainly billing the client for—clears his throat, and says, "Your Honor, I do not know the answer offhand. However, I have a spectacular leather-bound book in my office that discusses this exact issue. It has gold embossed lettering on the spine, the pages are edged in silver, and it perfectly matches the Persian rug in my waiting room." The judge, utterly unamused by this interior design update, rules against him and throws him in jail for contempt. The attorney possessed the books, he spent a small fortune acquiring them, and he proudly displayed them for all to see. Yet, because the actual knowledge contained within those pages was not accessible in his own mind, all that expensive leather was completely useless when the moment of truth arrived.

Nimshal: In Parshas Vaeschanan, we find the pasuk of Veshinantam Levanacha (Devarim 6:7). Rashi, quoting the Sifrei and the Gemara in Kiddushin 30a, explains the fundamental essence of Veshinantam: sheyihu mechudadim bepicha. Chazal elaborate on this exact madreiga: she'im yishalcha adam davar al tegameg vetomar lo, ela emor lo miyad. Unfortunately, many of us operate exactly like that foolish attorney. We invest heavily in the aesthetics of our Yiddishkeit. We boast magnificent sefarim shanks filled with custom-bound sets of Shas where the pages of Seder Kodashim are still physically stuck together from the printing press. We pay crushing tuition to send our children to the finest Yeshivos, assuming they will somehow absorb Torah through expensive osmosis. We proudly sponsor the kiddush—provided the herring is on sale, naturally—and we assume this covers our spiritual overhead. But when the moment of truth arrives—when a coworker asks us to explain a basic concept in halacha, or worse, when our own teenager asks us a fundamental hashkafa question at the Shabbos table—we stutter. We adjust our ties, look at the ceiling, and mumble, "That is a very good question, go ask your Rebbe," or "I have an Artsroll at home that explains this beautifully." We proudly point to the gold lettering on our shelves, but because our learning is not mechudadim bepicha, we are left speechless.

Practical Takeaway: The practical takeaway is that we cannot simply outsource our own bekias, nor can we rely on the geographic proximity of our sefarim to somehow inject knowledge into our brains. It is not enough to just cover ground in our learning, speeding through the Daf Yomi at such a breakneck pace that we sound like a frantic auctioneer, solely to reach the siyum on time. The Mishnah Berurah (Orach Chayim 47:2) explicitly codifies that the mitzvah of Talmud Torah requires actual comprehension, not just phonetic recitation. To properly fulfill Veshinantam, we must prioritize chazara. Relentless, uncompromising chazara. Pick one small, manageable area of halacha, or even one perek of Mishnayos, and review it until you absolutely own it. Learn it until you can explain it to a ten-year-old without breaking into a cold sweat and frantically searching for a footnote to save you. True Torah wealth is not measured by the linear footage of mahogany shelving in your dining room, or by casually mentioning that you once shared a delayed flight to Miami with a prominent Rosh Yeshiva. It is measured entirely by what you carry in your mind. Start small, review constantly, and ensure that the next time someone asks you a kasha, you can offer them a sharp, clear answer immediately, rather than just offering them a guided tour of your magnificent library.

GOOD SHABBUS!